

University of Colombo School of Computing

SCS 3312 : Research Methods

D1: Fieldwork Insights Report

**“An Investigation into Student Behavior During Free Periods Between
Scheduled Lectures at UCSC”**

Student Name and Index

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Abstract

This report presents the qualitative fieldwork phase of a study investigating how undergraduate students at UCSC, utilize their free periods between scheduled lectures. The study focuses on five campus locations — the UCSC Library, UCSC Canteen (Bawana), Common Room, Dewale, and Open Area — which represent the primary spaces students occupy during unscheduled time.

In this report, it is included the structured observations conducted across all five locations during morning and afternoon sessions over multiple weekdays. Also it includes short semi-structured interviews carried out with volunteering students at each location.

The report presents the raw observations per location, early interpretations of the behavioral patterns identified, a summary of interview responses, and location-specific and cross-location insights which are derived from the observations and interviews. The findings of this phase, form the foundation for the quantitative data collection and survey design to be carried out in the next D2 submission.

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List of Acronyms

UCSC — University of Colombo School of Computing

1 Introduction

University students experience regular unscheduled gaps between their scheduled lectures. These free periods are an unavoidable feature of the academic timetable and represent a significant portion of the daily campus experience. The way students use these free periods not only shows their mere time management, but also show how the students socialize, recover from academic load, and engage with the physical environment of the university. It also helps to understand whether the campus spaces available to students actually match what they need.

At UCSC, our team's research is focused on these five places, which are most commonly used by the students during free periods – The UCSC Library, UCSC Canteen (Bhawana), Common room, Dewale and the Open Area. Each of these locations have a distinct physical setting, social atmosphere, and set of implicit behavioral expectations.

This D1 report presents the qualitative phase of the research. Observations and short interviews were conducted to understand basic student behavior, before the quantitative measurement begins. The main research question guiding the study is:

“How do students utilize their free time between scheduled lectures within UCSC premises?”

The specific research questions are as follows:

- How do you usually spend your free periods based on the available time?
- Why did you choose this particular location today?
- Do you typically come here alone or with friends?
- What is your most preferred place to spend free time, and why?
- Are there any spaces on campus you avoid during free periods, and why?
- Do you switch locations during a single free period?
- Do you feel the campus provides adequate spaces for your needs between lectures?

These questions guided both the semi-structured interviews and the focus of the structured observations conducted across all five field sites.

2 Fieldwork Methodology

2.1 Observation Approach

Observations took place at the UCSC library, Canteen, Common Room, Dewale and Open Area on weekdays. The observations are taken sometimes as the whole group, and sometimes by each individual separately, based on the free time periods we had during lectures. In order to establish if there are any behavioral differences at different times of the day, observations took place in two time slots, 08:00 AM – 12:00 noon as the morning session, and 01:00 PM – 05:00 PM as the afternoon session. The amount of time that we spent at each location was between 30 minutes to 45 minutes. A non-participant approach was adopted at all times, and we tried to behave natural as much as possible, by attending to those places and continue with the natural activities, while typing the observations on our mobile phones unnoticeably, without interacting with the students who are being observed. We, group members managed to cover all locations during the free periods, thereby ensuring that all 5 spaces were repetitively observed in both time slots.

2.2 Interview Approach

In addition to the observations, we conducted short, semi-structured interviews with volunteering students at each site. We attempted to keep the interviews as short as possible, and also asked for the participants verbal consent at the beginning of each interview. Open ended questions are used to gather information about:

- how students use their free periods,
- how their activities and choice of locations differ based on the length of the free period (less than 30 minutes time periods are considered as short time periods while more than 30 minutes is considered as long periods),
- What are their most preferred locations and if there are any avoided spaces,
- Why they have chosen the current location and are they usually come there with alone or friends,
- Are they satisfied with the provided campus spaces for their needs.

2.3 Ethical Considerations

Notes were taken by typing the raw observations using our mobile phone notes app, with time stamps. No audio or video recordings were made. No personally identifiable information was collected — students were referred to by general descriptors only. Also each student is asked their verbal consent before the interviews.

2.4 Limitations

Observation sessions lasted only 30–45 minutes at each location, and interviews were conducted with a small number of conveniently available participants. Also the observer effects cannot be fully eliminated. Therefore, these findings should be considered as initial qualitative insights rather than conclusions that represent all students. The later quantitative phases of the study will help provide more generalizable results.

3 Structured Observations and Early Interpretations

3.1 Open Area

The open area consists of long benches with tables arranged in rows, open on all sides with a roof and floor. Charging points are attached to structural beams. The space is used by students from different years and occasionally by visitors from other faculties.

Structured Observations

- Students were observed studying with their laptops, writing down notes, and accessing the academic materials more often.
- Pairs or 3–4 groups of students were observed discussing some topics and clarifying subject related matters and watching videos.
- Solo students in the morning were mostly engaged in individual academic work — writing notes or working on laptops; in the afternoon, solo students were mostly on phones, scrolling or listening to music.
- Charging points were in regular use by students with laptops.
- On one occasion a group of students had moved into the space to make We-sak lanterns. They were cutting bamboo, pasting paper and putting frames together. Over the 30 minutes it could be observed that the group grew in size, as more students came to the place and started to contribute.
- Pairs and small groups of 3–4 students talking without any academic material on the table.
- When it is late afternoon, the number of students getting decrease.
- On hot days occupancy dropped and students moved to shaded spots or left.

Emerging Interpretation

The open area accommodates a wide range of activities without imposing fixed behavioral expectations, making it suitable for academic work, group discussions, and

cultural activities simultaneously. A clear shift was observed between morning and afternoon use — morning sessions showed purposeful individual academic activity, while afternoons were characterized by passive phone use and casual conversation. Personal phone calls were also observed, suggesting the open layout offers more privacy than enclosed spaces. For students with only very short free periods of less than thirty minutes this open space is more of a waiting area than a space for actual work.

3.2 UCSC Library

The library has individual study desks, a separate cubicle area with privacy partitions between each study space, as well as enclosed group study rooms with tables and chairs around it. There is also a separate book lending section.

Structured Observations

- The majority of students in individual areas were using laptops.
- Students who receive a phone call leave the area to take the call and return afterwards.
- Earphones and earbuds are used in individual study spaces while watching videos on their laptops.
- Group study rooms were used by students groups of 3–5 members. The students discuss academic related things or use their laptops.
- Some students were checking their phones for notifications or chats while working, but later again continue their work.
- Some students are observed sleeping with their heads on the desks specially during the afternoon session, but sometimes in morning session too.
- The book lending section was occasionally visited by 1 or 2 students in a session.
- Sometimes, students in the group discussion rooms were observed attending online meetings on laptops, speaking in low voices.

Emerging Interpretation

Most people who come to the library are students with academic purposes. The behavioral norms of stepping outside for phone calls, very little conversation, and wearing headphones for listening and watching to library media are maintained by most users in order to keep a focused environment. The physical layout of individual desks and cubicles as well as enclosed group rooms enables users to have different levels of focus and privacy. In addition, the rooms are used for online meetings because of the library's good acoustics that cannot be found elsewhere in the building. Sleeping in the library is observed to occur in both morning and afternoon sessions.

3.3 UCSC Canteen

The canteen has approximately 12 tables with chairs, a food and beverage service counter, two washing sink areas, and a small mounted television.

Structured Observations

- The canteen was less crowded in the morning and became busier in the afternoon, particularly around tea time (approximately 3 PM).
- Most students were present in groups, eating or having drinks while engaged in casual day-to-day conversation.
- Solo students were seen to be eating while they were on their phones, and they left the canteen as soon as they finishes their meals, most of the time.
- Most of the time, group students stayed longer than solo students in the canteen as they used the space to continue conversation after they finished their food.
- Some students in the queue at the counter were staring at their phones while waiting.
- Some students entered the canteen, found no available seats, and left without waiting, while others wait until someone finishes their meal.

Emerging Interpretation

The canteen is a social space rather than a dining facility. The majority of groups stayed long even after they finished eating, shows that canteen was used for further social interaction. Solo diners eat their food as quickly as possible and then leave the area, showing that social company is the main reason students choose to stay. Solo diners often used their phones throughout the time in the canteen, either while eating or waiting in the queue. Many students checked messages, browsed social media, or used the internet to pass the waiting time. It was also common to see students waiting for seats, while some chose to leave because no seats were available. This suggests that the canteen does not have enough seating capacity during peak hours.

3.4 Dewale Area

The Dewale has approximately 7 tables and chairs, two washing sink locations, a water filter, and fans. It is accessible to second-year and above students only. There is no food counter within the space.

Structured Observations

- Students with food containers sat alongside students with laptops or notebooks at adjacent tables.
- Some students finished eating, washed up, refilled water, and returned to the same seat to study.
- Solo students are sitting at individual tables with laptops and notes, engaging with academic work mostly.
- Most groups were 2–3 students having small discussions or casual conversation; but sometimes larger groups of 6–7 were present, with more noise and laughter, though the space did not remain consistently loud.
- Some students participated in online meetings on their laptops, speaking quietly, particularly when the space was less crowded.
- By the afternoon however the space tended to be less crowded with less academic work taking place. instead students having casual conversations with friends.

Emerging Interpretation

The Dewale space is able to act as a mid ground between the canteen and library to facilitate studying, completing assignments, attending online meetings and socializing. The space facilitated the ‘eat-then-study’ transition where people finished their meal and returned to the same seat to continue studying. Levels of noise were to vary between sessions but the space was generally quieter than the canteen. This space lacks strong enough norms to stop occasional disruptions but does return to a calmer state. Solo academic work shows that Dewale attracts students seeking quiet individual focus in a setting but do not prefer the library’s stricter expectations.

3.5 Common Room

The common room has an enclosed glass-door discussion room, counter-top seating along the wall, two large tables, and a carrom board.

Structured Observations

- Playing carrom games was observed in all of the sessions. Players would take turns shooting and those who were not playing would watch or chat with other students.
- Students with laptops seated at the countertop as well as in the discussion room and the big tables.
- In the afternoon session, most of the students can be seen sleeping, keeping their heads on the table. This behavior was considered as normal by others.
- When some students arrived, they were greeted by those already inside.

Emerging Interpretation

The common room is probably the most behaviorally diverse space of all those observed. In this place, students are most able to switch between studying, playing games, sleeping and socializing in a variety of different formats and without conflict. The carrom board functions not just as a recreational object but as a social anchor. Sleeping is treated as entirely normal, indicating the space serves as the campus's primary informal rest space.

4 Cross-Location insights from Observations

The emerging interpretations of Chapter 3 defined the behavioral characteristics of individual study locations. This chapter exposes common patterns that are only visible when all study locations are considered and directly relate to the research questions presented in this study.

4.1 Students match location to Activity, Not habit

Across all five locations, students consistently chose spaces that aligned with what they intended to do rather than defaulting to one place out of routine. Students heading to the library arrived with academic tasks in mind. Students going to the canteen want to meet or join friends. Students using the Dewale were often managing the transition between eating and working. This matching behavior suggests that the five locations function as a system rather than as separate independent spaces — students navigate between them based on need, and the system as a whole covers a range of activities.

4.2 Free Period Duration Shapes Both Location and Activity Type

The length of a free period apparently determined what students do during this time and even where they go to do it. Students with very short periods of free time apparently do not have time to go to the Dewale and thus go to the canteen, or the open area to just wait until their next lecture starts or else to do some small activity, rather than committing to a sustained task. In contrast students with longer periods of free time apparently have time to go to the Dewale or library to do academic work there. This indicates that students carry an implicit sense of what each duration of free time is suited to, and that location choice is mostly affected by what can realistically be accomplished before the next lecture.

4.3 Phone use is shaped by Context, not just by Individual

Phone use was observed in all 5 spaces but the nature of this behavior varied dramatically between spaces and between social contexts. Phone use was very short and purposeful in the library, while used to pass time in queues in the canteen. It

remained passive, but used as a method to pass the time in solo spaces i.e. open area/Dewale sometimes. This highlights that phone use is not a fixed behavior of individuals but can be influenced by space, and by the norms of each space.

4.4 Solo and Group students occupy the same space differently

Solo and group students used the same spaces in observably different ways — solo students used phones more, left sooner, and interacted less, while group students stayed longer, generated more movement, and used phones as shared social objects. This contrast was most visible in the canteen and open area. The pattern suggests that whether a student is alone or with others is a stronger predictor of their behavior than the location itself.

4.5 Environmental Conditions Filter Who Uses Each Space

Physical environmental factors affected where students went and for how long. Open spaces were used less on hotter days because of the heat but the presence of fans in the Dewale and of air conditioning in the library were pull factors. Charging points for electrical devices in the open and library spaces also affected where students chose to sit. These are physical factors that do not feature in formal description of the spaces yet have determined students' behavior.

5 Interview Summaries and Insights

The findings from the interviews reinforce the key points from the observations, and in addition reveal more dimensions about the use of the students' free time.

5.1 Location choice Factors

The main reasons for students choosing to study in certain locations on campus were the level of crowd in the location, the time to their next lecture, and the environmental characteristics of the location. Students stated that they chose to study in the Dewale as it was less crowded than the open area and common room. One student chose the Dewale that day not for comfort but for convenience — they had a meeting with a lecturer shortly after and needed to be able to move quickly. Furthermore, the fans in the Dewale and the air conditioning and charging points in the library were stated as positive environmental characteristics of the two locations. The open area was preferred by some of the students but stated to be too hot as there are no fans in the location.

“Because the crowd is minimized” — student at Dewale

“Convenient to work freely, and have charging points, and cool because of the AC” — student at Library

“Because can feel the natural breeze and can see the natural environment”
— student at Open Area

5.2 Activity by Free Period Length

Students clearly differentiated their behavior based on available time — short gaps for scrolling, eating, or chatting; longer gaps for library study and academic work. This was stated spontaneously across multiple interviews without prompting, suggesting that students make conscious decisions about how they use their free time rather than simply spending it without a plan.

“Short period: scrolling. Long period: doing academic and group project work” — student at Library

“Short period: eating, talking; Long period: using library and doing academic work” — student at Canteen

“Short period: checking LinkedIn, listening to songs; Long period: doing academic and group project work” — student at Library

5.3 Avoided Spaces

The canteen area was the most commonly avoided location by students due to reasons related to odor and flies. The open area was avoided primarily due to heat and because there were no fans in the area. The library was viewed positively by some for being quiet, but others avoided the space because it felt too enclosed or that they would be uncomfortable working there. One student described preferring the open area but moving to the Dewale when the open area became too crowded or hot, indicating students maintain a preference hierarchy rather than a single fixed destination.

“Canteen is avoided because of the odor and there are many flies” — student at Library

“Open is avoided because it is too hot” — student at Dewale

“Library is not preferred because it is like trapped inside the cubicle, so feel uncomfortable to work” — student at Common room

5.4 Space Satisfaction

Most students expressed dissatisfaction with campus spaces, citing overcrowding during peak times and a lack of natural environment areas as the main concerns. One student raised an unanticipated issue — the absence of any space for students who feel unwell. First-year students face additional constraints due to restricted access to the Dewale, leaving them with fewer options than senior students.

“Not satisfied, because most of the spaces are overcrowded” — student at Library

“Not satisfied, because there are less natural environment related places” — student at Canteen

“There is no place to stay when you get sick” — student at Library

“Actually now it is manageable as we are in 2nd year, but first year there were restrictions so then it was not enough space” — student at Dewale

6 Conclusion and Future Work

6.1 Conclusion

This report has presented the qualitative phase of a study investigating how UCSC undergraduate students utilize their free periods between scheduled lectures. Observations across five campus locations and fourteen interviews reveal that students navigate campus spaces with a clear implicit understanding of what each is suited for, with location choice shaped by intended activity, available time, social context, and environmental conditions.

Students spent their short free periods engaging in social and passive activities whilst longer free periods were spent on academic work. There were a number of ‘spaces gaps’ identified at UCSC including an insufficiency of space in the canteen, restricted Dewale access for first-year students, and the absence of any space for students who feel unwell.

The findings reported here are based on the observations and interviews with a relatively small number of participants and therefore are indicative rather than definitive. However, they provide a foundation for the design of the D2 survey which will test these findings on a larger sample of students.

6.2 Future Work

D2 – Data Collection Design and Pilot Report

Based on the findings and observations gathered during the qualitative phase, the research team will design quantitative data collection instruments such as structured response sheets, observation templates, and measurement criteria. A pilot study will then be conducted with a small sample in order to evaluate the clarity, practicality, and effectiveness of the data collection methods before large-scale quantitative data collection begins.

D3 – Data Summary and Preliminary Findings

The quantitative data collected during the study will later be organized, summarized, and analyzed using descriptive statistical methods such as frequencies, percentages, and basic comparisons. Preliminary findings regarding student activity patterns, preferred locations, peak usage periods, and behavioral trends will be identified and compared with the qualitative observations gathered during earlier stages of the re-

search.

D4 – Final Research Report

The final stage of the study will integrate both qualitative and quantitative findings into a comprehensive analysis of student behavior during free periods within the UCSC environment. The final report will critically evaluate behavioral patterns, campus space utilization, informal learning environments, and student experiences while also discussing the strengths, limitations, and possible implications of the research findings for university environments and future studies.

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